

D&D 3.5e Rods — Complexity Tier Classification

Companion to: rods_implementation_plan.md
Purpose: Classify all 36 rod items by implementation complexity
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Tier Overview

Tier	Stars	Description	Count	Est. Time Per Rod
1	★	Simple Passive / Single Toggle	2	0.5 days
2	★★	Single Active Ability	5	1 day
3	★★★	Multi-Use / Metamagic / Moderate Complexity	25	1-2 days
4	★★★★★	Multi-Ability Complex Systems	4	3-4 days

Tier 1 — Simple Passive ★

- Characteristics:**
- Passive bonuses while held (no activation required)
 - Single on/off toggle at most
 - No daily limits, charges, or complex state

Rod	Price	Key Mechanic	Implementation
Immovable Rod	5,000 gp	Button toggles fixed-in-space state	Set <code>isImmovable</code> flag; apply 8,000 lb weight limit; DC 30 to move. Minimal state.
Rod of Splendor	25,000 gp	+4 CHA enhancement while held	Apply stat modifier on equip, remove on unequip. Daily abilities (apparel/tent) are flavor, low combat impact — can be deferred.

Total Tier 1 Effort: ~1 day

Tier 2 — Single Active Ability ★★

Characteristics:

- One primary active ability
- Command word or use-activated
- May have daily limits but straightforward tracking
- No complex multi-mode behavior

Rod	Price	Key Mechanic	Implementation
Rod of Metal & Mineral Detection	10,500 gp	Detect metal within 30 ft (full-round)	Scan tiles in radius, highlight metal objects/deposits. Unlimited use.
Rod of Enemy Detection	23,500 gp	Detect hostiles within 60 ft, 3/day	Scan for hostile creatures, point toward nearest. Track 3 daily uses × 10 min each.
Rod of Cancellation	11,000 gp	Drain magic from touched item; rod destroyed	Melee touch attack → remove item enchantment → destroy rod. One-time-use item.
Rod of Negation	37,000 gp	Dispel item magic via ray, 3/day	Ranged touch attack → greater dispel magic vs item properties. Track 3/day.
Rod of Flame Extinguishing	15,000 gp	Extinguish fires, charge-based	10 charges/day, renewable. Different charge costs by fire size. Niche utility.

Total Tier 2 Effort: ~5 days

Tier 3 — Metamagic / Multi-Use / Moderate Complexity



Characteristics:

- Multiple uses or modes but within a single system
- Metamagic rods: integrate with spell casting, daily tracking
- Combat rods: weapon transformation + special effects
- May require new subsystems but scope is bounded

Metamagic Rods (18 variants)

All metamagic rods share a common system — implement once, parameterize for each type/tier.

Rod Type	Lesser (≤ 3 rd)	Normal (≤ 6 th)	Greater (≤ 9 th)	Key Mechanic
Empower	9,000	32,500	73,000	Numeric spell effects $\times 1.5$
Enlarge	3,000	11,000	24,500	Double spell range
Extend	3,000	11,000	24,500	Double spell duration
Maximize	14,000	54,000	121,500	All numeric values at maximum
Quicken	35,000	75,500	170,000	Cast as swift action
Silent	3,000	11,000	24,500	No verbal component needed

Shared Implementation:

- Metamagic system core: 3–4 days
- Per-type implementation: ~ 0.5 days each (3 days for 6 types)
- Tier variants are data-driven (change MaxSpellLevel param): ~ 0 extra days
- **Subtotal: ~ 6 –7 days for all 18**

Non-Metamagic Tier 3 Rods (7 rods)

Rod	Price	Key Mechanic	Complexity Notes
Rod of Python	13,000 gp	Transform to snake ally, 3/day + 1/week giant	Requires creature summoning system, basic AI, telepathic commands.
Rod of the Viper	19,000 gp	+2 heavy mace, poison serpent head 1/day	Weapon stats + poison effect (1d10 CON, Fort DC 14). Evil-only restriction.
Rod of Withering	25,000 gp	Touch attack: 1d4 STR + 1d4 CON damage	Apply ability damage on successful touch. Straightforward.
Rod of Flailing	50,000 gp	Transform to +3 dire flail; +4 AC/saves 1/day	Weapon transformation + defensive buff. Two distinct abilities.
Rod of Rulership	60,000 gp	Mass charm 300 HD, 120 ft, Will DC 16	Apply charm effect to multiple targets, track 500 min total usage.
Rod of Security	61,000 gp	Transport to safe demiplane	Create safe zone, track 200 person-days total. Mostly narrative.
Rod of Alertness	85,000 gp	+1 mace, +1 init, 8 at-will detects, alertness mode 1/day, animate 1/day	Many abilities but each is simple. Passive bonus + detect spells + group buff.

Subtotal: ~7-8 days for non-metamagic Tier 3

Total Tier 3 Effort: ~13-15 days

Tier 4 — Multi-Ability Complex ★★★★★

Characteristics:

- Multiple distinct ability systems
- Require dedicated managers/controllers
- Complex state management
- Novel mechanics not shared with other items

Rod	Price	Key Mechanic	Complexity Notes
Rod of Wonder	12,000 gp	d100 table → 20 unique effect categories	Must implement ~20 distinct spell/effect types. Random outcome engine. Each effect has different targets, saves, areas.
Rod of Thunder & Lightning	33,000 gp	5 distinct abilities (3 × 1/day, 1 × 1/day, 1 × 1/week)	Five completely different combat abilities. Mixed damage types. Combined mode.
Rod of Absorption	50,000 gp	Absorb spells → store levels → convert to slots	Novel absorption mechanic. Integrates with enemy spell casting and wielder's spell slot economy.
Rod of Lordly Might	70,000 gp	4 weapon forms + 3 spell-likes + climbing pole + compass + door forcing	Most complex rod. 6+ modes, each with different stats. Spell-like abilities. Utility functions.

Individual Estimates:

- Rod of Wonder: 3–4 days
- Rod of Thunder & Lightning: 2–3 days
- Rod of Absorption: 2–3 days
- Rod of Lordly Might: 3–4 days

Total Tier 4 Effort: ~11–14 days

Implementation Order by Tier

Recommended Build Sequence

Week 1: Foundation + Tier 1 (Immovable Rod, Splendor passive)
 Week 2: Tier 2 (Cancellation, Negation, Enemy Detection, Metal Detection, Flame Ext.)
 Week 3: Tier 3 – Metamagic Core System
 Week 4: Tier 3 – Metamagic All 18 Variants
 Week 5: Tier 3 – Combat Rods (Flailing, Python, Viper, Withering)
 Week 6: Tier 3 – Utility (Alertness, Rulership, Security)
 Week 7: Tier 4 – Wonder + Thunder & Lightning
 Week 8: Tier 4 – Absorption + Lordly Might

Dependency Graph

Foundation (Equip System, Rod Base Classes)

Tier 1: Immovable Rod, Splendor

Tier 2: Cancellation, Negation, Detection rods, Flame Ext.

Tier 3 Metamagic System

All 18 metamagic rod variants

Tier 3 Combat Rods

Withering (needs: ability damage system)

Viper (needs: poison system, alignment check)

Flailing (needs: weapon transform, dire flail stats)

Python (needs: creature summoning, basic creature AI)

Tier 3 Utility

Alertness (needs: detect spells, passive bonuses)

Rulership (needs: mass charm system, duration tracking)

Security (needs: demiplane/safe-zone logic)

Tier 4

Wonder (needs: ~20 spell/effect implementations)

Thunder & Lightning (needs: sonic damage, electricity, combined modes)

Absorption (needs: spell interception, spell slot restoration)

Lordly Might (needs: multi-form weapon, 3 spell-likes, utility modes)

Complexity Metrics Summary

Metric	Value
Total unique rod types	24
Total individual rod items	36
New systems required	6
Tier 1 rods	2
Tier 2 rods	5
Tier 3 rods	25 (18 metamagic + 7 other)
Tier 4 rods	4
Estimated total effort	7.5 weeks
Code files (new)	~12
Code files (modified)	~4